

| By Amitabh Srivastava |

Tears welling up in his eyes, the man hugged his grandfather, someone he had last seen more than a decade ago, someone he was told had died long ago. But the old man, an inmate of the Ranchi Institute of Neuro-Psychiatry and Allied Sciences (RINPAS) in Jharkhand, had been alive all these years, suffering silently even after he was cured of his mental illness. He seemed to have been erased from the memory of his sons till his grandsons found him and took him home. This family reunion that took place two years ago was an extraordinary sight for the RINPAS authorities and its inmates.

Extraordinary because such reunions between those cured of mental illness and their progeny are extremely rare. There are 91 RINPAS inmates who have fully recovered from their mental problems and yet the asylum is the only home they have. Abandoned by their families, they have nowhere to go. The silence at RINPAS hangs over a sea of empty stares. But there are some eyes that stand out for the anguish in them. These are real people in real situations. The stigma of mental illness has already shattered them from within but being abandoned is worse. One of the cruelest results of being abandoned is that the victims are alienated from those who can give them the love and support that is vital in dealing with mental illness. Lives are torn apart, friends and families are lost, and futures evaporate. "In fact, the families are needed most when delusions and hallucinations leave the patients alone in the most fundamental of ways. Unfortunately, this is the time when most families give up hope and just strike out the inmates from their family albums," says Dr Amul Ranjan, head of Clinical Psychology at RINPAS.

Thirty-five-year-old Shivani Ghosh from Ranchi is one of the abandoned inmates. Admitted here at the age of 14, she is now an attractive woman

GULAM KABARIA, 62

Admitted to RINPAS in 1975. Declared fit but his family is untraceable, forcing him to stay on in the asylum.



Abandoned by THEIR OWN

Mentally cured inmates are forced to stay on in the Ranchi asylum as their families don't want to take them back

with a heart of gold. Ghosh has also defeated the most debilitating of mental illnesses: schizophrenia. She was once discharged with a hospital escort but her family refused to recognise her, forcing her to be readmitted. Likewise, 80-year-old Chander Kiran of Patna was readmitted when her Patna-based brother refused to accept her. The case of 51-year-old Bela

Sinha is even worse. Her brothers refused to take her back even after she recovered from schizophrenia soon after her admission in 2000. Her troubles didn't end there. Sinha's husband, a lawyer, has now sent a legal notice to RINPAS saying that he can't be forced to keep the patient, as he did not admit her to the hospital. Clearly, he has moved on in life, leav-